

1. Company Value Proposition

We would like to talk with you about how AI-based demand forecasting could support your inventory planning, specifically around the seasonal and variant-heavy side of your business. This is not a sales pitch or an audit. It is a conversation to understand where forecasting tools like this actually help a company your size, and where they do not, so that whatever we write about it is grounded in how a business like yours actually operates, not just in what vendors claim. Since you have already gone through digital transformation projects with your product data and planning systems, your experience is genuinely useful to us, and we think reflecting on what worked and what did not in those earlier rollouts could be useful to you as well, going into any future decision about forecasting tools specifically.

2. Traced Questions

We removed questions that desk research already answers, such as who currently builds AI demand-forecasting tools, or how vendor jurisdiction differs between European, American, and Chinese providers. What is left below are questions that only Deventrade itself can answer, organized from broader context toward more specific detail.

Internal (current process and pain points):

- Could you walk us through how your team currently decides on order quantities and the size or color split for a product line, from the first forecast through to the final confirmed order? We are especially interested in where in that process things tend to go wrong.
- Where does the current process create the most rework or stress? For example, is it more often a broken size run, an overstock situation on a particular brand, or something in how orders are split across your retail network?
- You already run Slim4 for planning and Akeneo for product data. Looking back at those two rollouts, what would you say went well, and what would you do differently if you were starting them again today?

Internal (data and decision-making capability):

- How would you currently describe your team's understanding of AI-based forecasting specifically, as opposed to the rule-based planning you already do? Is there a shared sense internally of what "good enough" historical sales data would even look like for a model to learn from?
- Has anyone here already looked into or tried something like AI-based forecasting, even informally? What happened, and what was the reaction internally?
- If a forecasting tool like this were actually running day to day, who on your team would realistically end up responsible for it, and would that person need to learn something new, or does that capability already exist somewhere in the business?
- We found several failure points described in the literature, mostly documented at larger retail chains, things like poor historical data quality, high integration cost, and staff distrust of automated recommendations. Which of those feel like they would genuinely apply to a company your size, and which feel more like problems that only show up at a much bigger scale?
- How do you imagine your sales and planning staff would react to a tool that makes automatic quantity or allocation suggestions? Would that be seen as helpful, or would it need to earn trust first?

External-validation:

- Have you personally looked at, been pitched, or demoed any forecasting or planning tools recently, beyond what you already use? What stood out as realistic, and what sounded like marketing?
- Do vendors approach you directly about AI-based forecasting or inventory tools? If so, what kinds of claims do they typically make, and how do you usually judge whether to take them seriously?

3. Reciprocal Value

We can share a short written summary of what we find, specifically how AI-based demand forecasting tools compare for companies at your scale, along with an honest assessment of where we think it would and would not be worth the investment for you. As part of that, we can also put together a short readiness snapshot based on what you tell us, essentially an honest picture of where your team currently stands in terms of data, process, and capacity for a tool like this, so the summary is not only about the market but also about your own starting point. We aim to have that ready within one to two weeks after the visit.

4. Operational Protocol

One team member leads the questions and one takes notes, so the person asking can stay focused on listening rather than writing. We plan for the conversation to run about forty-five minutes to an hour, and we will confirm that timing with you in advance. Before any question is asked, we state three things clearly: the material will be anonymized and used for educational purposes only, we are not asking for actual sales or ERP figures in specific numbers, only descriptive answers, and the interview material will never be processed through a free-tier AI tool. Where it is stored instead is defined in our knowledge architecture document. If the conversation is recorded for our own note-taking accuracy, we ask separately and explicitly for permission to record, and that recording is deleted once it has been transcribed and anonymized.

Roleplay with AI

Q1 — Current process walkthrough:

"Sure. Roughly, our buying team starts looking at the upcoming season's assortment about six to eight months out. We look at last year's sell-through by style, adjust for what marketing is pushing that season, and Slim4 gives us a baseline quantity suggestion per SKU. Then someone manually reviews the size curve, because the system's default curve does not always match what a specific club or region actually needs. It goes back and forth a few times before we lock the order with the factory."

Q2 — Where the process breaks:

"Probably the size curve adjustment. That is still mostly done by feel, based on whoever has been doing it longest. When that person is out, or when we launch something genuinely new without sales history, it gets shaky."

Q3 — Reflecting on the Slim4 and Akeneo rollouts:

"Akeneo went reasonably smoothly, to be honest, once we got past the first couple of months. Slim4 took longer to trust. People kept overriding its suggestions for a while."

Q4 — Understanding of AI-based forecasting vs. current rule-based planning:

"I mean, we use forecasting software already, so I would say we understand planning tools. Whether that is the same as AI, I am honestly not sure."

Q5 — Prior informal attempts:

"Not really, no. It has come up in conversation but nothing beyond that."

Q6 — Who would own it:

"That would probably fall to whoever owns Slim4 now, but I would have to check whether that person has the bandwidth or the background for something like this."

Q7 — Which failure points apply at your scale:

"The data quality one, definitely, our historical data is not perfectly clean. The integration cost one, maybe. I am less sure about the staff distrust point, it depends who you ask."

Q8 — Staff reaction to automated suggestions:

"Depends on the person, honestly. Some people would welcome it, some would not."

Q9 — Vendors demoed recently:

"We get pitched fairly often. I could not tell you specifics off the top of my head."

Q10 — Vendor claims, realistic vs. marketing:

"Most of it sounds impressive on the call and less impressive once you ask for a reference customer our size."

Role reversal: as an external reviewer, which questions did not get an honest or complete answer

Stepping out of the role: three questions felt like the answer slipped away, either because the question was too broad, or because it asked for something that was not readily at hand during the conversation.

- **Q4** (understanding of AI-based forecasting) got a generic answer. The question was too abstract and did not point to a specific situation.
- **Q9** (vendors demoed recently) got "I could not tell you specifics off the top of my head." This is exactly the signal that we asked for something not readily available in the moment. This should either be asked for in advance, or narrowed down.
- **Q8** (staff reaction to automation) got a one-word, evasive answer. The question was closed and too general, and needs to be opened up and tied to an actual past situation instead of a hypothetical one.

Round 2 Log

Question	What happened	What we changed	Why
Q4 – Understanding of AI-based forecasting	Vague, generic answer	Made it more specific: "When you hear 'AI-based forecasting' specifically, as opposed to what Slim4 already does, what comes to mind first?"	The original question was too abstract
Q8 – Staff reaction to automated suggestions	One-word, evasive answer	Tied it to a concrete situation instead: "Can you think of a recent moment when Slim4's suggestion was overridden? What drove that decision?"	The question was closed and too general, needed to be open and grounded in a real situation
Q9 – Vendors demoed recently	"I could not tell you specifics off the top of my head"	Narrowed it and gave a clearer time frame: "Has a forecasting or planning vendor approached you in the last six months? What was the pitch?"	The original question asked for something not readily at hand

The remaining questions (Q1, Q2, Q3, Q5, Q6, Q7, Q10) produced concrete, specific answers. Q3, about reflecting on the Slim4 and Akeneo rollouts, worked especially well and is a pattern worth following elsewhere in the guide.

Partner team review

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